it was turned into a mini fortress, defended by barriers, sniffer dogs, armed gunmen, body searches and so on.

After every incident, LEAs reacted by enhancing police nakas (barricades) on roads and outside important buildings, which gave just an illusion of security. Until 2013, political rivalry between the federal and provincial governments was worse; therefore, whenever Peshawar or Lahore was attacked, the federal government would term it a provincial issue. The Punjab government rebounded with the allegations of lack of strategy and policy at the Centre. This trend changed after 2013 when the PML (N) governments were formed at the Centre and in the Punjab.

The government had almost always found an alleged foreign involvement in a terrorist act.

This approach misled people about the actual culprits. The interior ministers and provincial home ministers invariably blamed India after every terrorist attack. It seemed quite ludicrous when the TTP spokesperson claimed responsibility of the same incident. Although there was evidence of Indian support to TTP, it would have been better to clarify to people about the actual perpetrators instead of government supporters.

The government's policy to tackle banned organisations was ambivalent. SSP, LeJ, JeM and others kept operating with new names. However, in 2016, the Punjab government took strict action against LeJ as its dreaded leader Malik Ishaq, his 2 sons and 11 others were killed in a police encounter.

The Punjab government had made CID responsible for tackling terrorism and renamed it Counter Terrorism Department (CTD) and revamped it. For an initial few years, CTD's performance was quite poor due to lack of directions and strategy (Sehgal, 2010). However, after the formulation of the National Action Plan, CTD Punjab carried out a number of operations and killed many terrorists belonging to LeJ, Al Qaeda, TTP and IS in police encounters. Although the human rights organisations accused it of indulging in fake encounters, the chances of penalising them through courts was near to impossible. Records showed that terrorists were rarely convicted due to insipid investigation and placid prosecution (Hussain, 2010).

It could be safely concluded that unabated terrorist acts exposed the lack of a comprehensive counter-terrorism strategy. The government acted like a 'fire brigade dousing flames and doing damage control'.